

Business Requirements Document (BRD)

(with Functional Requirements, User Stories & Process Design)

Project: Seller Onboarding Enhancement for an E-commerce Marketplace

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Date: September 2, 2026

Version: 1.0

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1. Executive Summary

This document outlines the business requirements for improving the seller onboarding process on an e-commerce marketplace. Industry data shows that onboarding delays significantly increase seller drop-off, with up to 40% of sellers abandoning the process when onboarding extends beyond two weeks. This project proposes a streamlined onboarding workflow, supported by clear requirements, stakeholder alignment, and process redesign, to reduce time-to-first-listing and improve seller satisfaction. The recommendations in this document are based on requirement-gathering discussions with key stakeholders, current-state process analysis, and industry benchmarking.

2. Background & Objective

Background

Industry benchmarks show that manual seller onboarding processes can stretch to 6-8+ weeks, and marketplaces risk losing up to 40% of sellers when onboarding extends beyond two weeks (Netguru, 2024). In contrast, top-performing marketplaces activate sellers within 48 hours to keep abandonment under 10%, and platforms like Mirakl report an average time-to-first-sale of just 23 days (Mirakl 2023 Seller Report). This project addresses a similar onboarding delay problem for a hypothetical e-commerce marketplace, aiming to reduce time-to-first-listing and seller drop-off through improved requirements, process design, and stakeholder alignment.

Objective

Design a streamlined seller onboarding requirement set and process that reduces average time-to-first-listing, decreases seller drop-off during onboarding, and lowers manual support intervention - targeting activation within days rather than weeks.

3. Scope

In-Scope

- Seller application review and approval workflow
- Item/catalog setup and listing requirements
- Inventory readiness verification
- Onboarding progress tracking and reporting
- Seller-facing onboarding guidance/communication touchpoints

Out-of-Scope

- Seller payment/settlement processing systems
- Post-onboarding account management and ongoing seller support
- Marketing/advertising tools available to sellers after go-live
- Returns and refund policy management

4. Requirement Gathering Summary

The following requirements were informed by simulated stakeholder discussions, reflecting the types of input typically gathered from onboarding operations, seller support, and product teams during a real requirement-gathering phase:

- Onboarding Ops Manager: “Sellers often stall at the inventory upload step because the file format requirements aren't made clear upfront.”

- Seller Support Lead: “We get repeated tickets asking about onboarding status because sellers have no visibility into where they are in the process.”
- Product Manager: “We need a way to flag sellers who are stuck for more than 3 days so ops can proactively reach out.”
- Technology Team: “Automating the catalog validation step would remove a major manual bottleneck.”

5. Business & Functional Requirements (BRD + FRD)

Business Requirements

- BR-01: Reduce average seller time-to-first-listing from current baseline to under 10 days.
- BR-02: Provide sellers with visibility into their onboarding progress at every stage.
- BR-03: Reduce onboarding-related support ticket volume by automating status updates.
- BR-04: Enable ops teams to proactively identify and assist stalled sellers.

Functional Requirements (FRD-style detail)

Each functional requirement below includes the trigger, expected system behavior, inputs/outputs, and business rules -- the level of detail typically found in a Functional Requirements Document (FRD).

FR-01: Real-Time Onboarding Progress Tracker

- Trigger: Seller logs into the onboarding portal.
- Input: Seller ID, current onboarding stage from system database.
- System behavior: Display a visual tracker showing completed, current, and remaining steps.
- Output: Rendered progress bar/status page.
- Business rule: Steps must display in fixed sequential order; a step cannot show as “complete” unless its validation criteria are met.

FR-02: Automated Catalog File Validation

- Trigger: Seller uploads a catalog/inventory file.
- Input: Uploaded file (CSV/Excel format).
- System behavior: Validate file structure, required fields, and data format against predefined template rules.
- Output: Success confirmation, or an itemized error list (e.g., “Row 12: missing SKU”).
- Business rule: Files with critical errors (missing mandatory fields) are rejected; files with minor errors (formatting warnings) are accepted with a flag for review.
- Error handling: If the file fails to upload due to a technical error, the system displays a retry prompt and logs the failure for the Tech team.

FR-03: Automated Reminder Notifications

- Trigger: A scheduled daily check identifies incomplete onboarding steps older than 24 hours.
- Input: Seller's last activity timestamp, current onboarding step.
- System behavior: Send an email/in-app notification reminding the seller of the pending step.
- Output: Notification sent; log entry recorded.
- Business rule: Maximum of one reminder per 24-hour period per seller, to avoid over-notifying.

FR-04: Stalled Seller Flagging

- Trigger: Daily scheduled check for onboarding inactivity.
- Input: Seller's last activity timestamp.

- System behavior: If inactivity exceeds 3 days, flag the seller record on the Onboarding Ops dashboard.
- Output: Flagged seller entry with days-inactive count, visible to Ops team.
- Business rule: Flag is automatically cleared once the seller resumes activity (e.g., uploads a file or logs in).

FR-05: Weekly Onboarding Funnel Report

- Trigger: Scheduled weekly job (e.g., every Monday 6 AM).
- Input: All seller records with their current onboarding stage.
- System behavior: Aggregate seller counts by stage (applied, in-progress, live) and calculate week-over-week change.
- Output: Auto-generated report (PDF/dashboard) distributed to Product Manager and Onboarding Ops.
- Business rule: Report must include a trend comparison against the prior 4 weeks.

6. User Stories & Acceptance Criteria

The functional requirements above have been translated into user stories to guide development in an Agile format, with acceptance criteria and MoSCoW prioritization (Must have, Should have, Could have, Won't have).

US-01 (Must have): As a seller, I want to see a real-time onboarding progress tracker, so that I know exactly what step I'm on and what's left to complete.

- Given I am logged into the seller portal, when I view my onboarding dashboard, then I see my current step, completed steps, and remaining steps.

US-02 (Must have): As a seller, I want the system to validate my catalog file format instantly, so that I can fix errors without waiting for manual review.

- Given I upload a catalog file, when the file is submitted, then the system validates the format within seconds and displays specific errors if any are found.

US-03 (Should have): As a seller, I want to receive automated reminders for incomplete onboarding steps, so that I don't lose momentum or forget where I left off.

- Given I have an incomplete onboarding step for more than 24 hours, when the system checks for inactivity, then I receive an email/notification reminder.

US-04 (Should have): As an Onboarding Ops manager, I want stalled sellers (inactive 3+ days) automatically flagged, so that I can proactively reach out before they abandon onboarding.

- Given a seller has had no onboarding activity for 3 or more days, when the daily check runs, then the seller is flagged on my dashboard for follow-up.

US-05 (Could have): As a Product Manager, I want a weekly onboarding funnel report, so that I can track how many sellers are in each stage and identify trends.

- Given a new week begins, when the reporting job runs, then a report showing applications, in-progress, and live sellers is generated automatically.

Sprint Plan (Illustrative)

- Sprint 1: US-01 (progress tracker), US-02 (instant file validation)
- Sprint 2: US-03 (automated reminders), US-04 (stalled seller flagging)
- Sprint 3: US-05 (weekly funnel report), testing and refinement

7. Stakeholder Analysis

The table below maps key stakeholders by their level of power (influence) and interest in the project outcome, along with the recommended engagement approach:

Stakeholder	Power	Interest	Engagement Approach
Product Manager	High	High	Manage closely; involve in all key decisions
Onboarding Ops Manager	High	High	Manage closely; primary process owner
Seller Support Lead	Medium	High	Keep informed; gather frontline feedback
New Sellers (end users)	Low	High	Keep informed; collect satisfaction feedback
Marketing Team	Low	Medium	Monitor; involve for training/communication content
Technology/Product Dev	High	Medium	Manage closely; needed for system changes

RACI Matrix

Activity	Responsible	Accountable	Consulted	Informed
Seller application review	Onboarding Ops	Product Manager	Support Lead	Seller
Item/catalog setup	Seller	Onboarding Ops	Tech Team	Product Manager
Inventory readiness check	Onboarding Ops	Onboarding Ops	Seller	Support Lead
First listing go-live	Tech Team	Product Manager	Onboarding Ops	Seller, Marketing
Progress tracking/reporting	Onboarding Ops	Product Manager	Support Lead	All stakeholders

8. AS-IS Process (Current State)

The current onboarding process is largely manual and sequential, with limited visibility for the seller:

- 1. Seller submits application
- 2. Onboarding Ops manually reviews and approves application (1-3 days)
- 3. Seller manually uploads catalog/inventory files via email or portal
- 4. Ops manually validates file formats and flags errors back to seller (repeat cycle if errors found)
- 5. Once validated, Tech team manually publishes the listing
- 6. Seller has no visibility into status and contacts Support for updates

Key bottleneck: steps 3-4 (manual file validation) are the largest source of delay and repeated back-and-forth.



Figure 1: AS-IS Process Flow

9. TO-BE Process (Proposed State)

The proposed process introduces automation and visibility to remove the largest bottlenecks:

- 1. Seller submits application
- 2. Application auto-checked against basic eligibility rules; Ops reviews only flagged exceptions
- 3. Seller uploads catalog/inventory files through a self-serve portal
- 4. System automatically validates file format and shows errors to seller instantly (no ops involvement needed for standard errors)
- 5. Once validated, listing is auto-published without manual Tech intervention
- 6. Seller sees real-time status via a progress tracker; automated reminders sent for incomplete steps; stalled sellers (3+ days) auto-flagged to Ops

Expected outcome: removes the two largest manual bottlenecks (file validation, status visibility), directly targeting BR-01 through BR-04.

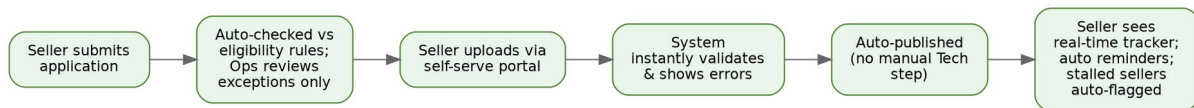


Figure 2: TO-BE Process Flow

10. Assumptions & Constraints

Assumptions

- Sellers have access to a self-serve onboarding portal with internet connectivity.
- Current average time-to-first-listing is estimated at 10-14 days based on typical marketplace onboarding patterns, in the absence of internal baseline data.
- Basic eligibility rules for seller applications can be codified into automated checks.

Constraints

- Solution must work within the existing marketplace technology stack.
- Budget and timeline for automation development were not defined for this case study and are assumed to follow a standard agile delivery cycle.
- Data privacy and compliance requirements for seller information were not assessed in detail within this scope.

11. Success Metrics / KPIs

- Average time-to-first-listing: reduced to under 10 days (from an estimated 10-14+ day baseline)
- Seller onboarding abandonment rate: reduced to under 15%
- Onboarding-related support tickets: reduced by 30%
- Seller satisfaction (post-onboarding survey score): target 4/5 or higher